How to Survive a Horror Movie

By Seth Grahame-Smith

INTRODUCTION

Let's face it, characters in horror films are pretty stupid. They make bad choices - leaving you to wonder if they have any brains at all. For example . . . They never turn on the lights . . . roaming around in the dark with a serial killer on the loose is a MUCH better option, right? They always go into the basement or wander alone in the woods. They taunt and encourage the killer to come after them in amazing displays of false bravado: "You want some of this – Come and get me, you freak!" They hear a sound and HAVE to go investigate. They utter the phrase: "Let's split up!" Of all the dumb things people in horror movies do – this is the dumbest! But . . . If you do find yourself trapped in a horror movie, worry not; today I'll be presenting you with a comprehensive guide to keep you alive until the credits start rolling.

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(From Chapter 1)

NARRATOR: Those of us who've become trapped in a horror movie have a choice: We can either line up with the other cattle and march into the slaughterhouse *(Moo!)* Or we can fight back. Yes, it's a long way to the final credits. No, the odds aren't in our favor. But that's no excuse to lie down and let the filmmakers have their way with us. (But you have to be smart!)

Horror movie characters aren't killed by machete-wielding monsters or reincarnated psychopaths— They're killed by ignorance. Ignorance of the mortal danger they're in. Ignorance of the fact that they're in a horror movie.

(So . . .) How do you know if you've been sucked into the Terrorverse? Sometimes the signs are unmistakable. For instance, if you're a teenaged babysitter caring for a mute toddler in a remote cabin during a blizzard while an escaped killer roams the woods, you're probably in a horror movie.

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TAKE A LOOK AROUND. The environment should offer some clues. If you're on a crowded city street in broad daylight, you're probably safe (for now). But if you're anywhere remote—the woods, an old house, an abandoned mental institution in the middle of a blackout—then yes, your chances of being in a horror movie are much higher.

Do you hear strange sounds? *(chi-chi-chi … ah-ah-ah)* out of nowhere? Are you speaking Japanese? *(utter phrases or words in Japanese – Typhoon, Karaoke, Anime, Emoji, Pokemon!)* According to the laws of early twenty-first century cinema, **anyone** speaking Japanese is in a horror movie. If the answer to any of these questions is "Affirmative," then we have to consider the possibility that you've become trapped in a horror movie.

As much as you may feel like crying or making skid marks in your tighty-whiteys, you'd better pull yourself together—and soon. Because if you don't, the boogeyman's really going to give you something to cry about. Your situation requires immediate action, and the C.R.A.V.E. method (COVER, RECON, ARSENAL, VEHICLE, ESCAPE) was developed for just such an emergency. It's a kind of "stop, drop, and roll" for horror movie victims—a way to stay alive long enough to summon your courage and get out of immediate danger

C: COVER. What you need right now is a temporary headquarters—a place to wipe the sweat from your brow, take a pull off the old asthma inhaler, and formulate your plan. Some of the best places to do that: Good ol' everyday houses. Though not ideal fortresses, the average two-story house is almost always the closest option. [Or] Water towers. If your movie takes place in a small Midwestern town, this might very well be the tallest structure around. If you can get to the top, you'll have a highly defensible (there's only that one long ladder to worry about) perch with a 360-degree bird's-eye view.

R: RECON. Now that you've had a moment to catch your breath, it's time to get an idea of where the enemy is and what he's up to. If you don't have the height of a water tower working for you, peek through the highest window in your hideout and take a look. If you see nothing, they're probably right behind you. *(begins to turn with a stricken look)* No, wait! Don't turn around; Nice and cool … that's it. Now, on the count of three, cover your

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face with your arms and jump over the rail or through the window. *(shows a fear of heights/jumping)* Either you jump or you die. Ready? One … two … just kidding, you're totally screwed . . . .

A: ARSENAL. You see a path to freedom—you'll need some kind of weapon. If you're barricaded in a house, look for a baseball bat, kitchen knife, or anything that kids aren't allowed to play with indoors. If you're holed up in a church, grab a heavy-duty candlestick. And if you're up on that water tower, get your hands on the nearest, um … actually, there aren't too many options with a water tower. You really should've thought of that before you climbed up there!

V: VEHICLE. You've summoned some courage, grabbed a weapon, and hopefully spotted a nearby unoccupied vehicle—now it's time to kick a little ass. In a burst of adrenaline-fueled speed. Your goal—your only goal—is to reach the nearest car or truck, get inside, and blow town as fast as inhumanly possible. Don't bother smashing the window—they left the car unlocked *(provide sound effects and pantomimes)* Lock the doors, and pull down the driver's-side sun visor. The keys will simply drop into your lap. When you try to start the engine, it'll turn over again and again, but don't worry—it'll kick in as soon as the attacker reaches the car and pounds on the windows.

E: Escape. This is the easy part. Put the car in "D," point the compass to "N," and get the "F" out of there.

[We've now come to that portion of this guide entitled] THE SEVEN DEADLY HORROR MOVIE SINS

1ST DEADLY SIN: DOUBT. There are two types of horror movie characters: those who believe your story and those who don't.

AS A PARENT: It was just a dream, honey.

NARRATOR: No it wasn't. Come on, people. Your son or daughter is having recurring dreams about getting brutally murdered night after night, and you're brushing it aside as what—indigestion?

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AS A SKEPTICAL TEENAGER*:* Those are just ghost stories our parents told us.

NARRATOR: Yes, and they just happen to be true. If all the moms and dads have spent the last 17 years telling you not to go into the abandoned mannequin factory, here's an idea: Don't go into the abandoned mannequin factory.

2ND DEADLY SIN: MACHISMO. [You'll recognize] The jock who thinks his football skills are enough to defeat the reincarnated serial killer. Remember, [if you are a] male—in horror movies, testosterone might as well be cyanide.

AS A JOCK: You want some of this?

NARRATOR: You know the guy. The one who just can't take it anymore.

AS A JOCK: What's your plan, huh? Sit and wait for that … that thing to pick us off one by one? No way, man! Not me.

NARRATOR: He runs out into the open, yelling something like

AS A JOCK: C'mon, show your face!

NARRATOR: And. . . well, you know how that ends.

3RD DEADLY SIN: INDEPENDENCE. *(In a Steve Erwin accent)* Have you ever seen that documentary about wildebeests? The one where it's nothing but slow-motion footage of them getting torn apart by lions and crocodiles? Great, isn't it? Funny how the predators always seem to kill the animals that are on the outer edges of the herd. The ones who are either too slow or too stupid to draw strength from their numbers. This is not a coincidence.

4TH DEADLY SIN: UGLINESS. Nobody said horror movies were fair.

5TH DEADLY SIN: CURIOSITY. - one of the basic horror movie equations: Investigation = mutilation.

AS A YOUNG GIRL: Is that you, Patches?

AS PATHCES: If "Patches" is your nickname for the man hiding in your closet with razorblades on his fingertips, then yes, it is.

AS A CLULESS TEEN: Do you think it's dead?

NARRATOR: No. Go ahead and poke it with a stick. We want to watch it grab your arm and bite half your face off.

6TH DEADLY SIN: IRRESPONSIBILITY. In a horror movie, if you accept a task and fail to carry it out, either you or someone close to you is going to die.

AS A CLULESS TEEN: Aw, what's a little nap gonna hurt?

NARRATOR: A lot.

AS A CLUELESS BABYSITTER: Trust me, the kids are sound asleep.

NARRATOR: No, the kids are dead.

AS A DISGRUNTLED TEEN: How come I always get the crappy jobs?

NARRATOR: Because you're an idiot, and you're about to prove that fact by failing miserably at the simple task you were assigned.

7TH DEADLY SIN: VEHICULAR SEX. Do it and die.

(From the Epilogue)

NARRATOR: [So . . .]When is it safe? When we see credits rolling in front of our eyes? Hear applause? When the killer suddenly takes off the mask, shakes our hand, and says, "Nice working with you"? No, it's never safe. Once you're in the Terrorverse, you're in for good—even after the movie that brought you there has wrapped. You succeeded in vanquishing the enemy? Great. Chances are you made it to the final credits, and you'll lead a long, peaceful life (especially if your movie bombs at the box office). But there will always be the possibility, however slight, that you'll be called back for sequels. (Ask Jamie Lee Curtis!) Screenwriters will keep dreaming up new villains and killing methods. Directors will get sleeker and bloodier. And the enemy will keep its fangs and machetes razor sharp . . . You'd better keep your skills the same way.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2013 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier - MS
NIETOC
IL State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier
ND State Qualifier

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